

How to Change a Money Pattern in Your Relationship

Maybe you tend to pay for everything and feel taken for granted. Or maybe you agreed on splitting expenses but circumstances have changed and you want to reexamine the agreement. Whatever the pattern, sometimes you need to make a change. Here are three things to know.

- 1. You can usually sense that an agreement requires changing by a single feeling: resentment.** What made sense in the past doesn't make sense anymore, and you resent being held to the old standards.
- 2. Most of us would rather feel that resentment instead of bringing this topic up.** Why? We don't know if we're being unfair. We worry how the other person will react when we don't have the knowledge and skills to change the pattern.
- 3. Once a pattern has been established, it's incredibly tricky to change it.** This is why it's ideal to get things right from the start.

The good news is that patterns can be changed. I've seen it happen over and over. The key is acknowledging the pattern, being crystal clear about what you want, and deciding what you're willing to do—and *not* do—to make the change.

It can go something like this:

"John, I want to have a difficult conversation. It's about a pattern in our relationship that I've noticed, and I want your help to change it. I know that I manage all of our finances, but it's important to me that you're involved too. I need your help in managing our accounts every month, and I think the way we talk about money will improve when we're handling it together. I know this will be a change, but it's important to me."

To help you prepare for these conversations, I've created a table on the opposite page: